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Witchcraft, oracles and magic among the Azande

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The ideas about the oracles that are in daily use are similarly obscure, though in speech the oracles are treated as though they were personal agents. The obvious suggestion is that the oracle is animistic, a personal agency, hearing and answering the questions put to it, an example of sheer animistic belief. Yet Dr. Evans-Pritchard, who knows the Zande as none other, clearly does not think so; rather is this a dogma constructed by ourselves:

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'The Zande actualizes... [his] beliefs rather than intellectualizes them, and their tenets are expressed in socially controlled behaviour rather than in doctrines. Hence the difficulty of discussing the subject of witchcraft with Azande, for their ideas are imprisoned in action and cannot be cited to explain and justify action.'

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The first step in combating witchcraft is to discover who is the witch. This is done by means of oracles or by witch-doctors. For the former Azande have a series of techniques different, so far as I can discover, from those of other peoples in the Sudan, and heretofore not adequately described or discussed in detail. The witch-doctors constitute a corporation, and their practices do not seem to differ greatly from those of their compeers in other African cultures. There is a certain amount of real or pretended dissociation, brought about by dancing, and the performers may gash their chests and tongues with knives, though this is not necessarily part of the ceremony. It would be interesting to know whether the medicines with which the witch-doctors prime themselves before dancing, avowedly to enable them to see the unseen and to resist fatigue, have, in fact, any deliriant or tonic action, or whether suggestion alone produces the results.  xix Dr. Evans-Pritchard tells me there are reasons for considering any real pharmaceutical action unlikely. In spite of the imposing technique of the dance and the effect on the audience of the drum and dance rhythms (I have myself watched this effect among self-styled Azande, really a subject people of the Azande nation from French territory), there is a body of frankly sceptical opinion concerning the witch-doctors; nor is this of recent origin, due to European influence. It would, perhaps, be fair to say that if there are some entirely genuine practitioners, there are many quacks. There are even tests, they might be called practical jokes, almost institutionalized, for proving, in other words, catching out, the witch-doctors. Moreover, there is the ultimate test of the poison oracle, regarded by Azande as infallible. This, not being under human control, is likely to contradict the witch-doctor if he has in fact used fallible human knowledge in place of, or to supplement, the verdict which he should voice as the result of the 'medicine' within his system. In fact, Azande assimilate their witch-doctors not to the poison oracle or even the termite oracle, but to the rubbing-board oracle, known to be fallible because manipulated by man. Yet, like this oracle, witch-doctors clear the air of witchcraft, and are useful in eliminating suspects before the poison oracle is consulted.

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